

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

General IT English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For IT operations, service desk, infrastructure, cloud, endpoint, security, and platform teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

03 Identity, Access, and Permissions

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

04 Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

05 Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

06 Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

07 Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

08 Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A ticket says "the system is down." The requester can sign in but cannot export invoices. Other functions have not been checked.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: Incident, Service request, Problem, SLA.

Model response

Which action fails, and what message do you see? I understand that sign-in works but invoice export does not. When did the problem start, and who else is affected?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Narrowing the invoice-export incident - The service desk clarifies the lesson's ticket: sign-in works, invoice export does not, and other functions are untested.
2. A printer queue needs an impact check - A separate fictional office: one receptionist reports a stuck label-printing job; another printer has not been tested.
3. A request for equipment is not a repair - A separate fictional onboarding case: a hiring coordinator requests a second monitor for a new starter; no existing device has failed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A missing shared-folder shortcut

In a fictional office, an employee's shared-folder shortcut no longer opens. The folder's web link still works. Only one device has been checked, and no files are known to be missing.

Role A: You are the service desk analyst. Clarify the failed action and affected scope.

Role B: You are the records coordinator. Explain the two observed outcomes and ask how the incident will be described.

Possible opening: The shortcut fails, but the web link opens; let's separate those two observations.

Success checks

- State both observed outcomes.
- Avoid claiming data loss or an organization-wide outage.
- Agree a precise ticket description and the next diagnostic question.

Add a complication: A manager wants the ticket labeled data loss even though no missing file has been identified.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

Staff can reach an internal application on the office network but not through the VPN. Someone announces that DNS is the cause without testing it.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: DNS, VPN, Gateway, Firewall.

Model response

The problem appears when users connect through the VPN. DNS is one possible cause, but we have not confirmed it. Let's record the tests and distinguish findings from hypotheses.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. The VPN difference is not a DNS diagnosis - Engineers examine the lesson's internal application, reachable in the office but not through the VPN.

2. One hostname works, another does not - A separate fictional network test: a laptop reaches the intranet hostname but not a reporting hostname; no DNS response has been inspected.

3. A firewall change and an uncertain cause - A separate fictional incident: connection errors appeared after a firewall change, but no rule-level evidence has been reviewed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The wired-versus-wireless comparison

In a fictional office, one laptop reaches a file portal over a wired connection but not over wireless. Both tests used the same account. No other device or network log has been checked.

Role A: You are the network analyst. Separate the confirmed comparison from possible causes.

Role B: You are the support lead. Challenge the claim that the wireless access point is definitely faulty.

Possible opening: The same laptop and account work over wired access, but that does not yet identify the wireless failure's cause.

Success checks

- Preserve the single-device scope.
- Describe an equipment fault as a hypothesis only.
- Agree another bounded check before recommending replacement.

Add a complication: Someone proposes replacing equipment immediately because the two results look decisive.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Identity, Access, and Permissions

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A temporary analyst requests administrator access to download a monthly report. A reporting role may provide the necessary access.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: IAM, Authentication, Authorization, Least privilege.

Model response

Could you confirm the report and actions you need? The reporting role may be sufficient. Please include the requested end date so the access owner can review the request.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Requesting the reporting role - The lesson's temporary analyst needs a monthly download and has requested administrator access; a reporting role may suffice.
2. Read access for a contractor review - A separate fictional project: a contractor must review one test dashboard for a week; editing is not part of the requested work.

3. Ending access after a temporary assignment - A separate fictional service team: an analyst's temporary reporting assignment has ended, but the corresponding role remains listed on the account.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A service account with too broad a request

A fictional overnight job needs to read one inventory table. Its request asks for database-owner rights. The data owner has not reviewed the request, and no write operation is required by the supplied job description.

Role A: You maintain the job. Request assessment of read access for the named table.

Role B: You administer access. Ask for purpose and approval, and explain why the broader permission is not assumed necessary.

Possible opening: The job description requires reading one table, so could we assess that narrower permission first?

Success checks

- Tie the request to the stated read operation.
- Keep data-owner approval pending.
- Reject speculative future needs as evidence for current broad access.

Add a complication: The project lead says broad access would avoid future requests, although future needs are undefined.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

Two cloud options cost \$800 and \$1,050 per month in a planning estimate. Only the second estimate includes backup storage.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: VM, Container, Region, Tagging.

Model response

The estimates do not yet cover the same items. The \$1,050 option includes backup storage; the \$800 option does not. Let's compare equivalent configurations before recommending one.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 • Conversations

1. Comparing cloud estimates with the same backup scope - The lesson's cloud estimates are \$800 and \$1,050 monthly; only the second includes backup storage.

2. An idle test VM still appears on the estimate - A separate fictional test environment compares a continuously available VM with a proposed scheduled VM; restart time has not been measured.

3. Container packaging is not a complete operating cost - A separate fictional service review compares a container deployment proposal with an existing VM estimate; monitoring is included only in the VM estimate.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two storage estimates use different retention

In a fictional planning exercise, storage option A assumes thirty days of backups and option B assumes ninety. Both use the same estimated daily data volume. The required retention period is not yet agreed.

Role A: You are the cloud analyst. Explain why the totals cannot yet establish the cheaper equivalent option.

Role B: You are the service owner. Discuss how to obtain the retention requirement before selecting an estimate.

Possible opening: The daily data assumption matches, but the backup retention periods do not.

Success checks

- Name the thirty-day and ninety-day difference.
- Keep required retention unresolved.
- Agree a like-for-like comparison after the requirement is confirmed.

Add a complication: A stakeholder proposes labeling the lower estimate best value before agreeing retention.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A patch reached 180 of 200 managed laptops. Twelve were offline; eight reported installation errors. A manager asks if deployment is complete.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: Patch, MDM, Asset inventory, Maintenance window.

Model response

The patch is installed on 180 laptops. Twelve were offline and eight returned errors. Deployment is not complete; I'll separate those groups in the follow-up report.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. A - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. One hundred eighty is not the whole fleet - The lesson's patch deployment reached 180 of 200 laptops; twelve were offline and eight reported installation errors.

2. A server patch installed but restart pending - A separate fictional server maintenance record shows the update installed; the planned restart and application check remain pending.

3. A device missing from the managed inventory - A separate fictional inventory review finds a listed laptop absent from the MDM report; its current location and management status are unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The kiosk configuration is only partly applied

A fictional deployment targeted ten kiosks. Seven report the new configuration, two were offline, and one has not returned a status. No functional checks have been completed.

Role A: You manage endpoints. Give a precise progress report and distinguish missing status from failure.

Role B: You own the kiosk service. Ask what remains before calling the rollout complete.

Possible opening: Seven kiosks report the configuration, but three statuses and the functional checks still need attention.

Success checks

- Account for all ten kiosks.
- Do not equate silence with success.
- Separate configuration status from functional verification and agree follow-up.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to count the silent kiosk as successful because it returned no error.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

An analyst notices an unusual sign-in alert and sends it to the response team. The account owner has not yet confirmed the activity.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: SIEM, Alert, Vulnerability, Audit log.

Model response

I'm handing over an unusual sign-in alert. The timestamp and alert details are attached; the account owner's confirmation is pending. Please acknowledge receipt and confirm who will coordinate the investigation.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. Handing over an unconfirmed sign-in alert - The lesson's analyst hands an unusual sign-in alert to the response team; the account owner has not confirmed the activity.
2. A vulnerability result without an exploit finding - A separate fictional security review: a scanner flags one test server; no exploitation evidence has been examined.
3. A SIEM alert with an incomplete time range - A separate fictional monitoring handoff: an analyst has saved an alert and ten minutes of audit logs; earlier activity has not been reviewed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | An attachment report before analysis

In a fictional company, an employee reported an unexpected attachment. The message reference is preserved in a restricted ticket. The attachment has not been analyzed, and the employee's interaction with it is unknown.

Role A: You are the service desk analyst. Hand over the report without labeling the attachment malicious.

Role B: You are the security responder. Confirm the evidence location and the two unresolved questions.

Possible opening: We have an unexpected-attachment report, but no analysis result or confirmed interaction history yet.

Success checks

- Keep maliciousness and user interaction unconfirmed.
- Use the restricted evidence reference instead of distributing the attachment.
- Confirm who will handle analysis and the interaction check.

Add a complication: Someone asks you to circulate the attachment broadly so colleagues can inspect it themselves.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A change notice gave the wrong maintenance date. It said Tuesday, but the approved window is Thursday. Users have already received it.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: Change, Rollback, Runbook, Problem.

Model response

Please disregard the Tuesday date in my earlier notice. The approved maintenance window is Thursday. I'm sorry for the confusion; the corrected notice below includes the exact time and time zone.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. Correcting Tuesday to Thursday - The lesson's change notice incorrectly announced Tuesday; the approved maintenance window is Thursday and users already received the notice.

2. Rollback available is not rollback completed - A separate fictional release: an update said rollback was complete, but the runbook only described an available rollback option; no execution is recorded.

3. Closing the incident did not close the problem - A separate fictional service incident is resolved, but the underlying-cause investigation remains open; an update mistakenly says all work is finished.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A notice names the wrong affected service

A fictional change notice names the payroll portal, but the approved change concerns the training portal only. The notice has been sent. No payroll work is in the approved scope.

Role A: You coordinate changes. Acknowledge the incorrect service name and state the correct scope.

Role B: You lead support. Ask how users will receive the correction and how the approved record will remain intact.

Possible opening: The notice incorrectly named payroll; the approved change concerns the training portal only.

Success checks

- Name the communication error clearly.
- Keep approved scope separate from the incorrect notice.
- Agree to send an explicit correction through the original distribution route.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests adding payroll maintenance now to make the original notice accurate.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A service dashboard shows normal server CPU usage, but users report slow checkout. A colleague says the dashboard proves the service is healthy.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: Log, Metric, Trace, Error budget.

Model response

CPU usage tells us about one part of the system. It does not measure the whole checkout experience. Let's compare it with request latency and errors for the affected period.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Normal CPU does not measure checkout speed - The lesson's service shows normal server CPU while users report slow checkout.

2. A running pod is not a successful purchase - A separate fictional Kubernetes service: its pods are running, but no customer-journey test has been reviewed.

3. An error budget is not permission to ignore users - A separate fictional reliability review: a service remains within its agreed monthly error budget, but users have reported a new failure pattern.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Averages hide a slow group

In a fictional dashboard, average request time is unchanged, but five saved user traces show long waits at checkout. The sample's representativeness and the cause are unknown.

Role A: You are the observability engineer. Explain how an average differs from individual request traces.

Role B: You are the product lead. Ask what the five traces establish and what further evidence is needed.

Possible opening: The average is unchanged, but these five traces show delays that the average alone doesn't explain.

Success checks

- Distinguish an aggregate metric from request-level evidence.
- Keep the affected population and cause uncertain.
- Agree a bounded investigation without dismissing the observed delays.

Add a complication: A stakeholder wants to claim that every customer is affected based on the five traces.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.